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UNSC

Background Guide

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1. Welcome Letter

Distinguished delegates:

2013 saw the global order quietly slip off balance. In Ukraine, long-suppressed tensions over identity and deep divisions about the country's foreign-policy direction surfaced all at once. Political polarization and separatist tendencies intensified, putting national stability under severe strain. Meanwhile, the flames of conflict in the Middle East continued to spread. Struggles over power, governance, and security escalated—civilian casualties kept rising, the shadow of chemical weapons controversies still loomed, and extremist forces found space to grow. As multiple crises intertwined, the international situation became increasingly opaque; behind the scenes, competition among major powers was quietly shaping the direction of events.

In this historical simulation, the United Nations Security Council will no longer be a mere observer, but a crucial actor responsible for communication, coordination, and conflict de-escalation. Through multilateral consultation, diplomatic bargaining, and the use of international mechanisms, the Council seeks a possible balance amid regional disorder. Delegates with global vision and a sense of diplomatic responsibility—the Security Council awaits you here to write the choices of 2014. In a moment of turbulence, the hands of history have already turned toward 2014.

周浩浩 (Madelyn)

Dais Head of UNSC

2. Historical Background of the 2014 Ukraine Crisis

By dividing the world into the United States and the Soviet Union, a bipolar security order defined the entire Cold War experience. NATO and the Warsaw Pact, which gave rise to opposing military coalitions across Europe, were formed to sustain this divided power structure. Inside this system, Western European countries remained connected to the transatlantic security structure, while Eastern Europe became a geographic location for Soviet influence as a geographic buffer for the generating powers and instability of Eastern Europe was supplied as well by the alliance the two sides established with one another. Between those opposing powers, rather than having political trust provide stability, there was instead first the use of alliance discipline, second the use of deterrence, and third the defining of clear spheres of influence to provide the necessary stability.

The dissolution of the Warsaw Pact, which concluded in 1991, resulted in a change in the relation among the countries that constituted the alliance. Now, the new Soviet leadership perceived internal political and economic instability as the greater danger than external military threats. Consequently, the dissolution of the alliance destabilized the international situation of superpower relations and NATO still existed but lacked a distinct role in a unipolar world. The collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991 resulted in the creation of 15 new states each with the added problem of having to establish themselves as nations, introduce economic change, and realign their security interests.[1]

In Eastern Europe, the loss of centralized Soviet authority created a great deal of uncertainty. Renegotiating borders, military assets, and alliance commitments was necessary, and existing defense guarantees were eliminated. Consequently, a security gap emerged in the area. No comprehensive post-Cold War settlement had taken the place of the bipolar balance. Subsequent tensions in the European security order would progressively escalate against the structural backdrop of this transitional environment, which was marked by institutional realignment, changing alliances, and conflicting security perceptions.

The dissolution of the Warsaw Treaty Organization (the "Warsaw Pact") and dissolution of the Soviet Union did not lead to disbanding NATO; rather, NATO continued to exist as an institution by keeping its legal structure. The fundamental basis for the institutional structure of NATO is Article 5 of the North Atlantic Treaty, which provides for the principle of collective defense; that is to say, an armed attack by any one member nation against another member nation shall be considered an armed attack against all NATO states and shall require all of the states in NATO to assist the attacked party, including providing military assistance should the attacked party request it. During the period of Cold War, Article 5 functioned as a significant component of the U.S. policy of containment, an effort by the U.S. to deter the expansionist policies of the Soviet Union through guaranteeing the military solidarity of the United States and the member nations of NATO across the Atlantic Ocean. The concept of "keeping the Russian out" reflects the intent of the NATO alliance to maintain an effective strategy of deterrence and cohesion.[2]

In light of the collapse of the Soviet Union, NATO re-evaluated its role in the world today. NATO became less about defending specific territories and more about providing a broader range of security in terms of political stability and growth. As part of NATO's overall strategy, it was determined that expanding NATO's membership to include more countries would foster increased stability within the Euro-Atlantic area according to the 1995 Study on NATO Enlargement. As a result, NATO viewed that by adding new members, it would contribute to European integration and strengthening transatlantic relationships as well as serve as a support to help democracies meet their goals of civilian oversight of the military, transparency in defense planning, and cooperative ways to achieve security.[3] At the same time, several Eastern European countries submitted formal requests for NATO membership based on their belief that NATO would provide them security and an ongoing guarantee of their sovereignty into a changing European Order.

2.1. Ukraine's Geopolitical Location and Internal Identity Structure

Due to being situated directly in between two major superpowers (the European Union and the Russian Federation), Ukraine's geographic location has made it strategically important. This is similar to the relationship that exists today between Europe and Africa with regard to Israel. Prior to 1991, Ukraine was an important country in the former Soviet Union and the largest economy and population after Russia in that country. Ukraine was primarily an agricultural producer and had a number of military bases (one of which is still referred to as the "Black Sea Fleet of the USSR"). As part of the dissolution of the USSR, Ukraine declared

independence from the Soviet Union in short order, which represented one of the fastest acts of dissolving an organization that was a superpower.

Ukraine's geographic location affects its geopolitical positioning due to the amount of access that Ukraine has to the Black Sea via its coastline. Historically, the Russian Black Sea Fleet has been based at Sevastopol, which has enabled Russia to launch military campaigns from the naval base outside Russia; as such, Ukraine's coastal region is critical to Russia's ability to project power within the Black Sea and throughout the Mediterranean; therefore, any maritime security assessment conducted in respect to the Black Sea or Ukrainian-Russian relations must include consideration of Ukrainian coastline.

Since independence, Ukraine has experienced many problems as it tries to maintain its sovereignty while attempting to work within conflicting external alignments; the large number of ethnic Russians in Ukraine further complicates the process of establishing a constructive balance between Ukraine and Moscow. Ukrainian leaders from the current administration have focused on developing closer ties with Western institutions such as NATO and the European Union despite continued difficulties with the Russian government; however, internal cultural and political divisions have affected Ukraine's ability to make choices regarding relationships with other countries. The western part of the country is primarily Ukrainian-speaking and, therefore, generally supports closer ties to Europe. In contrast, the eastern and southern parts of Ukraine are populated almost exclusively by ethnic Russians and, therefore, tend to be more supportive of developing closer ties with Russia.

According to census data regarding language usage (pre-2014), the majority of the population in Ukraine considered the Ukrainian language their mother-tongue (approx. 66%) while the second largest portion, approximately one-third, identified as Russian speaking. Smaller groups of ethnic minorities (e.g., Romanian/Moldovan and Hungarian speakers) tend to be located near border areas. While these linguistic and cultural characteristics are not apparent when viewed from a political perspective, they are significant in establishing the regional fragmentation that characterizes Ukraine's history. Ukraine's geopolitical location coupled with its social and cultural history creates a complex basis for decision-making regarding its strategic options, as well as increasing Ukraine's vulnerability as it becomes increasingly dependent on others for its external security now and in the future.

2.2. Energy Transit and Economic Interdependence

The strategic significance of Ukraine has been enhanced through its access to the Black Sea. Most of the Russian Black Sea Fleet has been based in Sevastopol, Crimea historically, therefore controlling this naval base is vitally important to projecting Russian power into the Black Sea and to the Mediterranean Sea. Because of the maritime orientation of Ukraine's territory, maritime security has great implications for how these regional dynamics affect bilateral relations with Russia.

Since gaining independence, Ukraine has been engaged in strengthening its sovereign authority through reconciling competing external orientations. The difficulty in balancing

Ukraine's relationship with Moscow has led successive governments to seek out closer ties to Western institutions like NATO and the EU. There are also significant societal/cultural divisions that have complicated these strategies from an external perspective. The end of 2008 was marked by disputes regarding natural gas pricing and a temporary disruption of natural gas supplies through Ukraine; in both examples natural gas supply has been used as a political weapon.

The European Union's reliance on Russian natural gas, a significant portion of which is currently transported by Ukraine, creates a dilemma for EU policymakers regarding energy supply and security diversification. Accordingly, the potential for instability along Ukraine's gas transit routes will have ramifications extending beyond Ukraine and Russia's bilateral relationship to include the wider economic and security interests of the EU.

2.3. NATO and EU Enlargement and Its Structural Impact

NATO Expansion

One of the most significant changes in the post-Cold War European security environment was the expansion of NATO. Former Warsaw Pact members Poland, Hungary, and the Czech Republic were admitted into the Alliance during the first round of enlargement in 1999. NATO's eastward expansion beyond the borders of Cold War Western Europe began with this action. In 2004, the Baltic nations—Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania—that had previously

been part of the Soviet Union were included in a second, larger round that included seven more states.

From the perspective of the newly admitted states, membership meant formal security guarantees under Article 5 and symbolic integration into Euro-Atlantic political bodies. At the same time, from the Russian perspective, the eastward expansion of a military alliance historically intended for containment meant the contraction of its strategic "buffer zone" and encroachment on its sphere of influence.

The aforementioned can be understood as an example of the "security dilemma" concept. This concept implies that actions taken by one party to achieve greater security—such as the formation of a military alliance—may be perceived as a threat to the security of another party. Thus, NATO enlargement from the perspective of the security dilemma can be understood as a contributing factor to the deteriorating relationship between Russia and the West.

EU Enlargement

Looking at NATO enlargement and EU enlargement simultaneously moving eastward, ten new states were added to the EU in 2004 and these states were all Central/Eastern European and the enlargement of the EU incorporated additional regulatory and political frameworks into the east in addition to incorporating post-communist states into the EU single market). As part of their efforts to create an Eastern Partnership initiative in 2009, the EU established six Eastern European and South Caucasus nations as a part of this partnership which includes

providing political and economic integration to Ukraine. Key aspects of EU engagement with Ukraine included an EU-Ukraine Association Agreement (that sought to create a liberalised trade environment) and reinforced regulatory and institutional cooperation between institutions.

Also, Russian regional integration initiatives (e.g. Eurasian Economic Union) also pose a unique regional integration challenge for the EU; as both NATO/EU and Russia engage in regional integration activities, Ukraine has become a battleground for competing regional integration trends. This scenario emphasises how militarily/economically expanding NATO and EU created a series of structural tensions in the eastern European region during the early 2010s.

3. Domestic Political Situation in Ukraine (2010–2013)

3.1. Strategic Orientation Division and Identity Division

Following the election of Yanukovych to power in 2010, his cabinet members supported pragmatic partnership with Ukraine the European Union and Russia. This policy of balancing cooperation with several political units is however indicative of more socially divided than actually geopolitically flexible.

In particular, Ukraine has been traditionally characterised by regional differences on the language, economic organization and collective memory. Specifically, the western and central parts of the country are more inclined to comply with the European institutions and rules of governance. This is so because these regions believe in the incorporation of European methods of governance where they consider it as a means of attaining modernization and law reform. To the contrary, eastern and southern regions are the ones that are highly industrialized with Russia and advocate policies of sustaining economic relations with Moscow (Wilson, 2014). These rifts cause the political rift of political parties in Ukraine.

As scholars note, the foreign policy decisions of Ukraine have been in the past, a kind of proxy of national identity accounts. Thus, the actions that might be taken in favor of Europe or Russia could be viewed at home as a zero-sum geopolitical accommodation (Kuzio, 2015). By 2013, the EU Association Agreement talks turned the graphs of these layers of division into the centre of national political struggle, further polarising the regions, parties, and social groups (Young et al., 2015).

3.2. The Weakness in the domestic Ukrainian economy and the dissatisfaction of the citizens

Besides the tensions between the two countries on the geopolitical level, the domestic stability of Ukraine within the period between 2010 and 2013 was also highly limited due to the structural economic drawbacks. The post-Soviet Ukraine continues to have the bulk of its

industrial base in low-value-added manufacturing and energy-intensive sectors, which both restricts its competitiveness in the global market and further increases its dependence on external partners (Kuzio, 2015).

Reliance on Russia also limited fiscal independence, especially with the pricing structure of gas which regularly created political and economic pressure (Kuzio, 2015). Ukraine has been hit by a deep-seated economic down turn after the world financial crisis. The growth of GDP became negative after 2008. Stagnation of the economy, decrease in industrial output, and fiscal strain became the characteristics of 2012–2013 (World Bank, 2014). The situation with public finance has grown more shaky, which increases the political sensitivity of reform actions.

In the meantime, there is potential integration associated with structural integration to the European Union. It is generally assumed that the short-term social and economic consequences of such measures like subsidy reduction, fiscal and anti-corruption reforms will be adverse, and hence, controversial politically (Wilson, 2014). This period continued to be rife with corruption. The Transparency International Corruption Perceptions Index 2012 put Ukraine 144th out of 176 countries, which means that Ukraine is ranked among the lowest performing states in the region of Europe (Transparency International, 2012). These ratings were based on deep-rooted oligarchic control of political parties, state corporations, and the government to regulators, which led to a reduction in popular opinion of the political order.

In November 2013, President Viktor Yanukovych government stated their decision to suspend the process of signing the EU Association Agreement due to the economic risk and the necessity to preserve trade relations with Russia (BBC News, 2013). The ruling was preceded by even stronger economic pressure by Russia and came along with a financial assistance package of Moscow, including a loan guarantee of up to 15 billion dollars and a massive cut on gas prices (Financial Times, 2013). The news instantly led to protests in Kyiv and other capitals of the country, and the wave of protests started to develop in what came to be known as the Euromaidan movement (BBC News, 2013). What had started as a technical economic choice quickly turned into a wider political activism showing how the issues of economic vulnerability intersected with identity and governance grievances. Economic vulnerability, in turn, was not really a self-generating process; instead, it increased political polarization, and expedited mass mobilization in an already polarized society (Wilson, 2014).

3.3. Democratic Backsliding and Institutional Erosion

In the meantime, the political institutions of Ukraine have lost their credibility and independence in the course of this time. Reforms in the constitution and judicial rulings reinstated the significant powers of the president and undid the reforms that had been put in place following the Orange Revolution.

Selective justice, media pressure, and weakened checks and balances are some of the issues that are of increasing concern to international observers. The arrest and conviction of former

Prime Minister Yulia Tymoshenko in 2011 gained critic attention and it was generally considered to be a politically based prosecution of opposition leaders.

The European Parliament officially has threatened to impose a warning that the situation with the rule of law and judicial independence in Ukraine is worsening, which will destroy the perspectives of the country to cooperate more closely with the European institutions (European Parliament, 2012). On the same note, Freedom House has reported the downtrend in the performance of the Ukrainian democracy by referencing to a shrinking of media plurality, heightened executive branch control over the judiciary, and apprehension of election fairness. This has led to the citizens becoming more aware that political competition is no longer held on the institutional contests in a fair environment and thus undermining legitimacy of the regime (Freedom House, 2013).

3.4. Late 2013 Accumulation of Legitimacy Crisis

As of 2013, the domestic politics of Ukraine experienced a convergence of pressures, which were hardly experienced at the same time in a semi-democratic state:

- Heavy polarization of the society, geopolitically.
- Deprivation and poverty of dissatisfaction caused by corruption.
- Claimed institutional unbelievability and democratic lack of trust.

A political scientist, Lucan Way, describes Ukraine as a system of pluralism by default, i.e. political competition was not as strong due to effective democratic institutions but rather because no one actor could monopolize the system. Although this pluralism brought about resilience in certain times, it also brought about weakness at times of economic or geopolitical shocks.

4. Pre-Crisis Developments Leading up to the Ukraine Crisis

4.1. Domestic Political Situation in Ukraine (2010–2013)

Since 2010, Ukrainian President Viktor Yanukovych had attempted to pursue closer relations with the European Union while maintaining Ukraine's traditional political and economic collaboration with Russia. However, by 2013, this balancing strategy became increasingly difficult to execute. Negotiations between Ukraine and the European Union about the Association Agreement were nearing completion, but Russia exerted significant pressure on Ukraine's economy and financial system, particularly through trade restrictions and energy-related leverage, aim at prompting the Ukrainian government to postpone the signing of the agreement.[1]

The suspension of the agreement triggered large-scale demonstrations in Kyiv. The protesters initially demanded new and more collaboration with the European Union. These demonstrations later expanded into a broader anti-government movement, commonly referred to as the Euromaidan protests.[2]

4.2. November 2013 – January 2014: Expansion of Protests and Escalation of Violence

The protests were initially led by students and pro-European activists but they progressively expanded to include more general demands regarding unemployment, corruption, and the opaqueness of government decision-making. Protesters primarily gathered at Maidan Nezalezhnosti (Independence Square) in central Kyiv. Protests expanded to western cities like Lviv and other areas as scale grew larger and clashes between protesters and security forces became more intense.[3].

The government's response to the demonstrations further intensified political polarization. Ukrainian society became deeply divided between those supporting closer integration with Europe and those favoring continued alignment with Russia.

4.3. February 2014: Regime Change and a Crisis of Legitimacy

The level of violence in Kyiv peaked in early February 2014, resulting in significant casualties. Amid mounting political pressure and the loss of parliamentary support, President

Yanukovych was removed from office by the Ukrainian parliament on 22 February 2014 and subsequently fled Kyiv. While several states recognized the new political authorities, Russia and its supporters argued that the removal violated constitutional procedures and constituted an illegal coup.[4]

The Verkhovna Rada (Ukrainian parliament) appointed Oleksandr Turchynov as Acting President and established a transitional government. There was a major power vacuum in Ukraine during this time, especially in its defense and security institutions.[5]

4.4. Late February – March 2014: The Crimea Crisis and Annexation

Shortly after the change of government in Kyiv, the situation in the Autonomous Republic of Crimea and the city of Sevastopol changed rapidly. Crimea had long maintained close historical and cultural ties with Russia, possessed a predominantly Russian-speaking population, and hosted Russia's Black Sea Fleet.[6]

Unidentified armed individuals appeared throughout Crimea in late February 2014 and seized control of important military and government buildings. A referendum was then declared by the local Crimean parliament. According to reports, the referendum on March 16, 2014, yielded overwhelming support for Crimea's accession to the Russian Federation and secession from Ukraine. Russia officially incorporated Crimea and Sevastopol as federal subjects on March 18, 2014.

While Russia stressed the principle of self-determination and its own security interests, the Ukrainian government and most of the international community condemned these actions as violations of Ukraine's sovereignty and territorial integrity.[7]

4.5. April – June 2014: Emergence of Instability in Eastern Ukraine

Following the Crimea crisis, instability spread to eastern Ukraine, particularly in the Donetsk and Luhansk regions. These areas had historically maintained closer economic, cultural, and linguistic relation with Russia, and many residents questioned the legitimacy of the interim Ukrainian government.

Armed groups loyal to Russia took control of government buildings starting in April 2014 and proclaimed the creation of self-proclaimed states like the Luhansk People's Republic and the Donetsk People's Republic. These developments prompted military responses from the Ukrainian government and resulted in localized armed clashes.

By June 2014, while the conflict in eastern Ukraine had not yet escalated into a full-scale war, it had become a central component of the broader Ukrainian crisis and signaled the onset of a prolonged political and security confrontation.[8]

5. Major International Actors and Their Positions

5.1. Major Blocs and State Positions

The Ukraine crisis rapidly transformed to a political struggle from domestic level into an international confrontation revealing clear polarization among major global players. Among the players, different states adopted distinct positions according to their security concerns, geopolitical interests, economic ties, and ideological preferences. Specifically, these positions can be broadly categorized into three groups: the Western bloc, Russia and its strategic partners, and states that pursued a strategy of neutrality or balance.

5.2. The Western Bloc

United States

It was the role of the United States to take the lead by supporting Ukraine at the beginning of the crisis. Washington condemned the Russian annexation of Crimea as a pure violation of international law and Ukrainian sovereignty. The United States responded with several series of economic sanctions on Russian financial institutions, energy companies, and political leaders, and at the same time provided Ukraine with financial resources, training soldiers, and defensive weapons.[4] The policy was mostly driven by the general idea of maintaining the post-Cold War international order. From the American perspective, the behavior of Russia was a dilemma to the fact that national boundaries must not be changed by using power. As a

result, the aid to Ukraine became one of the pieces of a more general strategic operation that tries to discourage and stop further Russian growth, consequently calm the allies in Eastern Europe.

European Union

The European Union also expressed strong political support for Ukraine, although its internal position was more complex. The EU placed economic sanctions against Russia and reinforced its political and economic cooperation with Ukraine through the Association Agreement.[5] However, the crisis exposed some apparent divisions in the attitude toward Russia within the EU. For instance, countries such as Poland and the Baltic states viewed Russia as an immediate security threat and pushed for a harder line due to the geopolitical situation. In contrast, Germany, France, and Italy had to balance their political stance with their economic reliance on Russian energy.

Within the UN Security Council, this Western position was reinforced by non-permanent members such as Lithuania, Luxembourg, Australia, and the Republic of Korea, all of which supported resolutions recognizing Ukraine's territorial integrity.[6] Lithuania in particular adopted a highly critical stance toward Russia due to its historical experience with Soviet Union's rule, as well as its extreme sensitivity to threats to regional security.

NATO

To the NATO, the Ukrainian crisis was a way of reasserting its original objective of being a collective defense organization. Such efforts were made even though Ukraine was not the member, as the alliance intensified the deployment of its military forces in Eastern Europe and it focused on Poland and the Baltic states[7]. These measures were intended to deter potential Russian aggression and to calm the fear of member states that they might be the next target.

5.3. Russia and Its Strategic Partner

Russia

The main participant in the crisis was Russia. It accepted the annexation of Crimea on the basis of historical connections, the safety of Russian speaking nationals and the outcome of the local referendum.[8] Geopolitically, Moscow considered Ukraine as an important buffer zone between Russia and NATO. The possibility of Ukraine becoming closer to the Western institutions was seen as the direct threat towards Russian national security. Above all, Russia exercised its ability to veto resolutions in the UN Security Council, which wanted to condemn the annexation of the Crimea, which is an indication of limitation of the structure of the institution, when one of the permanent members is directly a party to the conflict.

Belarus

During the crisis, Belarus was the nearest political and strategic alliance of Russia. Even though it tried to have some diplomatic maneuverability, its security and economic reliance on Russia ensured that it mostly held a similar stand to Moscow.[9] A number of non-permanent members of the UN (such as Chad and Rwanda) were inclined not to confront Russia directly and focused on dialogue over punitive actions, which were part of the wider UN. Their careful policy had the indirect effect of lessening diplomatic pressure on Moscow and a desire to be politically even toed as opposed to being bloc directed.

5.4. Neutral and Balancing Powers

China

China adopted a cautious and relatively neutral position. It insisted on the significance of sovereignty and territorial integrity and voted against western sanctions on Russia as well. Most conspicuously, China did not vote on critical resolutions of the UN Security Council instead of approving those resolutions that directly criticized Moscow.[10] This dual stance reflected several strategic considerations. China did not want to establish any precedents regarding the issue of the territories, did not want to ruin the relations with both Russia and the European Union, and wanted to appear as the proponent of the diplomatic decisions.

India

India also pursued a policy of neutrality. It avoided openly condemning Russia while continuing its economic and defense cooperation with Moscow. At the same time, India did not formally recognize the annexation of Crimea, which allowed it to preserve its growing partnerships with Western countries.[11] This is a sign of the wider policy of strategic independence in international relations of India.

Turkey

Turkey stood in a special position in the crisis. Being a member of NATO, it was able to help Ukraine with their territorial integrity although they did not completely take part in the Western sanctions against Russia.[12] The ability to preserve the economic relations with Russia on one side and cooperate with Ukraine in security generated space on the other hand and serve as a mediator at the same time showed that Turkey was ambitious to establish itself as a regional power in the Black Sea region.

Global South countries, such as Argentina, Nigeria, Chile, and Jordan, and some other countries (Chad and Rwanda) demanded peaceful talks and did not take a decisive position in the conflict.[13] Their voting behavior in the UN Security Council frequently involved abstentions, reflecting concerns about economic stability, food and energy security, and a broader reluctance to support Western-led sanction regimes. These states did not see the crisis ideologically, but instead applied the prism of national interest and diplomatic flexibility,

which is a manifestation of the increased significance of multipolarity in the international system.

Conclusion

The international response to the Ukraine crisis revealed a fragmented global order rather than a simple bipolar confrontation. Although to a large extent the western bloc was operating in defense of the liberal international system, Russia was trying to regain its ground in its adjoining region. At the same time, major non-Western countries and several Global South nations took up soft policies on the basis of national interest and not political orientation.

The use of the veto in the UN Security Council, combined with the large number of abstentions, highlighted both the institutional limitations of the UN system and the emergence of a more complex multipolar international order.

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